

TUTORIAL

How to Crochet in the Round: Joined vs Spiral Rounds Explained

The two ways every circular or tube-shaped project is built — and how to know which one your pattern wants.

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Anything worked outward from a center point — hats, coasters, amigurumi, blankets started from the middle — is "worked in the round." There are two different ways to do this, and patterns don't always spell out which one they mean. Getting it backwards is one of the most common early mistakes, so this guide covers both, plus how to spot which one a pattern is asking for.

Starting point: the magic ring

Both methods usually begin the same way, with a [magic ring](#) (or a small chain joined into a loop). The difference starts at the end of round 1.

Method 1: joined rounds

Steps

1. Work your foundation ring and the stitches required for round 1.

2. Slip stitch into the top of the first stitch of the round (or the starting chain) to join and close the round.
3. Chain 1 (for single crochet) or chain 2–3 (for half double or double crochet) — this is your new "turning chain," even though the work isn't actually turned.
4. Work your first stitch of the next round into that same first stitch, or into the space the chain created, then continue around.
5. Repeat join → chain → continue for every round.

Method 2: continuous spiral rounds

Steps

1. Work your foundation ring and the stitches required for round 1 — with no joining slip stitch.
2. Place a stitch marker in the last stitch of the round (the first works too, just stay consistent).
3. Keep working stitches in a continuous spiral, moving the marker up into the last stitch worked at the end of every round.
4. Because there's no seam, the round spirals very slightly rather than stacking perfectly flat — this is normal, and is exactly what keeps amigurumi seamless.

How to tell which one your pattern wants

If a pattern says "join with a slip stitch," "ch 1, turn," or gives a stitch count that resets with each labeled round, it wants joined rounds. If it says "work in a continuous spiral" or "do not join," it wants spiral rounds, and you'll need a stitch marker to keep your place.

Common mistakes

- Losing track of the round without a stitch marker on a spiral pattern — the most common amigurumi mistake.
- Joining a spiral pattern by accident, which creates a visible stepped seam where a smooth shape was expected.
- Twisting the starting ring itself before working round 1, which carries a twist through the entire project.

Frequently asked questions

Do I need a stitch marker for spiral rounds?

Strongly recommended — without one, it's very easy to lose your place after just a few rounds, especially in a solid color.

Can I convert a joined-round pattern to spiral, or the reverse?

Not directly, since joined rounds include a turning chain that adds to the stitch count and spiral rounds don't — it's best to follow whichever method the pattern specifies.

What's the small "step" I sometimes see in amigurumi?

That's the natural result of spiral rounds never being joined. Most crocheters place their final decrease or seam at that spot deliberately, to hide it.

Written by Emily Hartwell

Emily has been crocheting for over a decade, ever since her grandmother taught her the basics one summer. She started CrochetGuides to write the clear, honest, beginner-friendly instructions she wishes she'd had when she was learning — the ones that actually work the first time.